day's march beyond wherever his small army of supporters happened to be camped. This chaos and instability created increasing difficulties for the kafilas – the great caravans heading to and from the cities of Central Asia – which in the absence of central authority could be taxed, tolled or looted by any tribal leader at will. This in turn severely threatened the political economy of Afghanistan by clogging the arteries through which passed the financial lifeblood of the Afghan state.

Afghanistan was still capable of supplying the whole region with three lucrative products – fruit, furs and horses. The looms of Kashmir still produced the finest shawls in Asia, and its crocuses the best saffron. Multan was famed for its gaudy chintzes. In good years there were also taxes to be collected from the kafila merchants travelling the Afghan trade routes bringing silk, camels and spices from Central Asia to India, and carrying back cotton, indigo, tea, tobacco, hashish and opium. But during the political unrest of Zaman's and Shuja's reigns, fewer and fewer kafilabashis were willing to take the risk of travelling through the dangerous Afghan passes.[29] In contrast to the confidence of previous generations, more and more Afghans were beginning to see their own country as an impoverished dead-end, 'a land that produced little but men and stones', as one of Shah Shuja's successors later put it.[30]

With little money coming in through taxes or customs, Shuja's only real assets were the loyalty of his blind brother, Shah Zaman, and the advice of his capable wife, Wa'fa Begum, who some believed to be the real power behind the throne. There was also the additional asset of the family's fast-diminishing treasure chest of Mughal jewels.

An alliance with the East India Company was therefore of the greatest importance for Shah Shuja, who hoped to use it to gain the resources with which he could unite his fracturing empire. In the long term, the British would indeed succeed in uniting the Afghans under a single ruler, but in a rather different way to that planned by Shuja.

By the end of October 1808, Elphinstone and his ambassadorial caravan were heading through the Shekhawati towards Bikaner, out of the Company's dominions and into the wind-blown wastes of the Thar Desert – virgin territory for the British.